Alexander Ross

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Academic Appointments

- **Postdoctoral Researcher** **Fall 2024 - March 2026**
  Université Laval, Department of Political Science
  Center For The Study of Democratic Citizenship

Education

- **PhD in Political Science** **2024**
  University Of California Riverside, Department of Political Science
- **Master of Public Policy** **2017**
  University Of California Riverside, School of Public Policy
- **Bachelor of Arts in Political Science** **2013**
  University Of California Riverside, Department of Political Science

Dissertation

- Title: ***Owed: The Politics of Student Debt***

My dissertation investigates how federal student loan debt affects the political engagement and attitudes of debtors and non-debtors. Student loan debt is relatively unique among the factors that influence one's financial situation. It can increase perceived precarity in the way that other financial stressors known to potentially reduce participation and affect policy preferences do, such as unemployment and low income status. But it is also though often held by people with distinct characteristics from those impacted by other stressors that might counteract the participatory and attitudinal consequences of greater financial distress (e.g., higher education levels). Using a series of survey experiments and observational tests, I assess the impact of debtor status on student debtors' political participation and policy preferences. I do so both in the absence of political stimuli and in response to policy proposals regarding said debt. I also, through survey experiments, examine the determinants of support for policies perceived to benefit debtors and attitudes towards debtors themselves among non-debtors. My findings suggest that debt is unique as a socio-economic stressor, with behavioral impacts distinct from what the literature finds with other comparable phenomena, and have implications for the literatures on poverty and inequality.

Committee: Dr. Daniel Biggers (Chair), Dr. Jennifer Merolla, Dr. Loren Collingwood

Research Interests

- Political Behavior, Politics of Personal Debt, Politics of Inequality, Online Political Behavior, Public Policy

Publications

- **Strategic Considerations and Support for Direct Democracy in the United States**
  with Daniel R Biggers. *Electoral Studies*
  https://doi.org/10.1016/j.electstud.2023.102716

Revise and Resubmit

- **Group Threat and Solidarity: Evidence from Yelp Reviews of Mexican Restaurants**
  with Adam Hobbs and Loren Collingwood
  Revise and resubmit at *Public Opinion Quarterly*

Under Review

- **Deserving Debtors? The Determinants of Attitudes Toward Federal Student Loan Debtors**
- **Buying Love? How Government Benefits Shape Immigrant Political Attachment**
- **Home Sweet Home? Foreign Real Estate Investment and Redistributive Preferences**
  with Adam Hobbs
- **Home is Where the... Immigration Attitudes Are?**
  with Adam Hobbs

Working Papers

- **Owed Gratitude? The Impact of Attempted Debt Cancelation on Attitudes and Behaviors**
- **Debtors and Democracy: The Impact of Federal Student Loan Debt on Participation and Attitudes among Debtors**
- **Voting and Proactive Social Norm Compliance**
  with Daniel R Biggers
- **BLM Protests and Online Reviews of Black-Owned Businesses: Evidence from Yelp and Google Reviews**
  with Adam Hobbs, Deren Onursal, and Tre Garnett
- **In the Line of Fire: Evidence of Political Shocks in Gun Retailer Online Consumer Behavior**
  with Stan Oklobdzija
- **Rating the Reckoning: Gender-Salience Shocks and Online Reviews of Women-Led Businesses**
  with Adam Hobbs
- **Enforcement on the Ground: ICE Detentions and Online Reviews of Mexican Restaurants**
- **Race, Party, or Both? Racially Polarized Voting After Callais**
  with Loren Collingwood, Nazita Lajevardi, and Hannah Walker

- **Dropbox Proximity and Voting Propensity**

  with Loren Collingwood and Benjamin Gonzalez O'Brien

Invited Talks

- **Yelp Stars and Partisan Stripes: What Online Reviews Reveal About How We Respond When Politics Makes an Identity More Salient**

  Whitworth University, November 2026

Conference Presentations

- **Group Threat and Solidarity: Evidence from Yelp Reviews of Mexican Restaurants**

  with Adam Hobbs and Loren Collingwood. Presented at the PNWPSA Conference, 2026

- **Yelp Stars and Partisan Stripes: Evidence of Affective Polarization in Online Business Reviews**

  with Adam Hobbs and Loren Collingwood. Presented at the MPSA Conference, 2026

- **Participating in Integration Activities and Participating in Quebec Society: A Study of Integration Programs' Use and Impacts**

  with Valérie-Anne Mahéo and Thomas Gareau-Paquette. Presented at the CPSA Conference, 2025

- **Housing Shocks and Redistributive Preferences**

  with Adam Hobbs. Presented at the MPSA Conference, 2024 & APSA Conference, 2025

- **Owed Gratitude? The Impact of Attempted Debt Cancelation on Attitudes and Behaviors**

  Presented at the APSA Conference, 2024

- **Deserving Debtors? The Determinants of Attitudes Toward Federal Student Loan Debtors**

  Presented at the APSA Conference, 2023

- **Debtors and Democracy: The Impact of Federal Student Loan Debt on Participation and Attitudes among Debtors**

  Presented at the MPSA Conference, 2023

- **Voting and Proactive Social Norm Compliance**

  with Daniel R Biggers. Presented at the APSA Conference, 2023

Teaching Experience

- **Instructor of Record**

  UC Riverside, Political Science Department

  Money In Politics (2021)

  American Politics (2022)

  Politics of the Underdeveloped World (2023)

  Regulation: A Political Perspective (2024)

- **Teaching Assistant**

  UC Riverside, Political Science Department

  American Politics, Comparative Politics, Elections and Political Participation, Global Politics, Political Ideologies, Politics of Mexico, Politics of The Underdeveloped World.

  UC Riverside, School Of Public Policy

  Intro to Public Policy, Politics and Public Policy, Policy Evaluation

Grants

- UC Riverside Graduate Division, Dissertation Year Program Fellow, Fall 2022
- UC Riverside Political Science Department, Gabbert Research Funds Award, Fall 2022
- UC Riverside Graduate Divisions, Dissertation Completion Fellowship Award, Winter 2024
- Center for the Study of Democratic Citizenship (CSDC), Conference Travel Grant, 2025

References

- Dr. Daniel Biggers
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  Professor & Chair
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